



Gypsum

△ **Example** of rough satin spar gypsum

Transparent crystals of gypsum are called selenite, named after the Greek moon goddess, Selene. The name may originate from the ancient belief that certain transparent crystals waxed and waned with the moon, and the crystal is still popular with enthusiasts of spiritual gems. A fibrous variety of selenite with a silky lustre is known as “satin spar”; when cut *en cabochon*, fibrous gypsum produces a cat’s eye effect, but it is too soft for general wear.

Specification

Chemical name	Calcium sulphate hydrate	Formula	
CaSO ₄ ·2H ₂ O	Colours	Colourless, white	Structure Monoclinic
Hardness 2	SG 2.3	RI 1.52–1.53	Lustre Subvitreous
to pearly	Streak White	Locations	Mexico, USA



Fishtail twin | Rough | Twin crystals of gypsum growing in mirror image along a centre line such as this are referred to as fishtail twins.



Gypsum crystals | Rough | These gypsum crystals growing from a rock groundmass have their faces highlighted by an iron oxide coating.



Desert rose | Rough | Spherical aggregates of gypsum crystals, such as this, that form in some relatively dry climates are called “desert roses”, a reference to the flower-like appearance of their crystals.



Selenite crystal | Rough | Transparent or highly translucent gypsum is called selenite, and has several crystal forms, one of which is shown here.



Satin spar | Cut | Gypsum sometimes forms masses of long, parallel crystals known as satin spar, and shows an “eye” when cut *en cabochon*, as here.